

Lecture 3.

Historical Context of the Creation of Pakistan — 1857 to 1930

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The creation of Pakistan was not the result of a single event or the efforts of one individual. It was the outcome of a long historical process shaped by the social, political, religious, and cultural conditions of British India. From the War of Independence in 1857 to Allama Iqbal's Allahabad Address in 1930, Indian Muslims gradually developed a distinct political consciousness. Events such as the Urdu-Hindi controversy, the Partition of Bengal, the Simla Deputation, the establishment of the All-India Muslim League, the Lucknow Pact, the Nehru Report, and Quaid-e-Azam's Fourteen Points played important roles in this development.

The War of Independence of 1857 and Its Consequences

The War of Independence of 1857 was a major uprising against British rule in India. Although people from different religious and social communities participated, the failure of the revolt had particularly serious consequences for Muslims. The British associated many Muslims with the former Mughal ruling class and considered them among the major opponents of British authority.

The Mughal Empire was formally abolished, and the last Mughal emperor, Bahadur Shah Zafar, was removed from power. Muslims suffered political decline, economic difficulties, and reduced access to government employment. Their educational condition also deteriorated because many Muslims initially remained suspicious of Western education and the British system.

Meanwhile, many Hindus began to take advantage of English education and new administrative opportunities. This gradually created differences in educational and economic development between the two communities.

Sir Syed Ahmad Khan and the Aligarh Movement

In this difficult situation, Sir Syed Ahmad Khan emerged as an important Muslim reformer. He believed that Muslims could not progress without acquiring modern education, particularly scientific and English education.

He established educational institutions and eventually founded the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College at Aligarh, which later developed into Aligarh Muslim University. The Aligarh Movement promoted modern education, social reform, and political awareness among Muslims.

Sir Syed also became increasingly conscious of the political differences between Hindus and Muslims. He argued that the two communities had different religious traditions, historical experiences, social customs, and cultural identities. His educational and political efforts laid an important intellectual foundation for later Muslim political consciousness.

The Urdu-Hindi Controversy

One of the earliest major cultural conflicts between Hindus and Muslims was the Urdu-Hindi controversy. In 1867, demands emerged in parts of northern India for Hindi to replace Urdu as an official language.

Urdu had a particularly important position in Muslim intellectual and cultural life. It was associated with Muslim literature, education, poetry, and cultural identity. The campaign for Hindi therefore created a sense among many Muslims that their cultural and linguistic identity could be threatened by the majority community.

The controversy convinced Sir Syed Ahmad Khan that Hindu and Muslim interests could differ significantly. Language, therefore, became not merely a cultural issue but also an important political question.

Partition of Bengal, 1905

In 1905, the British government divided Bengal into two administrative units. Eastern Bengal had a large Muslim majority, while western Bengal had a larger Hindu population.

Many Muslims welcomed the partition because they believed that the new province of Eastern Bengal and Assam would provide them with greater opportunities for education, employment, administration, and economic development. However, the Indian National Congress and many Hindu political leaders strongly opposed the partition.

The anti-partition movement included the Swadeshi Movement, which encouraged the boycott of British goods. Due to strong political pressure, the British government eventually annulled the partition in 1911.

The reversal of the partition had a significant psychological impact on Muslims. Many Muslims concluded that they needed an organized political platform to protect their interests.

The Simla Deputation, 1906

A major development in Muslim political history occurred in 1906 when a delegation of prominent Muslim leaders met the Viceroy, Lord Minto, at Simla. This delegation is known as the Simla Deputation.

The Muslims demanded adequate political representation and argued that their representation should take account of their historical importance and political position rather than simply their numerical strength.

One of their most important demands was separate electorates, under which Muslims would elect their own representatives. The British government eventually accepted this principle.

The Simla Deputation was important because it demonstrated that Muslims were becoming politically organized and conscious of their separate political interests.

Establishment of the All-India Muslim League

In December 1906, the All-India Muslim League was established at Dacca. Its initial objectives were to protect Muslim political rights, promote loyalty toward the British government, and develop political cooperation among Indian Muslims.

At this stage, the Muslim League was not demanding a separate country. Its primary concern was the protection of Muslim political interests within India. However, political developments over the following decades gradually transformed the League into the leading organization of the Pakistan Movement.

The Lucknow Pact, 1916

In 1916, the Muslim League and Congress reached an agreement known as the Lucknow Pact. Congress accepted the principle of separate electorates for Muslims and agreed to certain political safeguards.

Quaid-e-Azam Muhammad Ali Jinnah played an important role in promoting Hindu-Muslim cooperation at this stage. The Lucknow Pact demonstrated that cooperation between the two communities was possible, but later developments showed that their political differences were deeper than initially expected.

Khilafat Movement and Hindu-Muslim Unity

After the First World War, Indian Muslims became concerned about the future of the Ottoman Caliphate. This led to the Khilafat Movement. Muslim leaders such as the Ali brothers organized political campaigns to protect the institution of the Caliphate.

Mahatma Gandhi and Congress also supported the movement for a period, hoping to strengthen Hindu-Muslim unity. However, this unity did not last. The decline of the Khilafat Movement, political disagreements, and growing communal tensions eventually weakened cooperation between the two communities.

Nehru Report and Jinnah's Fourteen Points

In 1928, the Nehru Report proposed a constitutional framework for India. Many Muslim leaders considered its proposals inadequate because they believed that sufficient safeguards for Muslim political interests had not been provided.

In response, Quaid-e-Azam Muhammad Ali Jinnah presented his Fourteen Points in 1929. These included demands for federal government, provincial autonomy, adequate Muslim representation, and the continuation of separate electorates.

The Fourteen Points became an important statement of Muslim constitutional demands and demonstrated the growing political distance between Congress and the Muslim League.

Allama Iqbal's Allahabad Address, 1930

A major intellectual milestone came in 1930 when Allama Muhammad Iqbal delivered his famous presidential address at the annual session of the Muslim League at Allahabad.

Iqbal emphasized that Islam was not merely a private religious belief but also provided a social and political framework. He proposed that the Muslim-majority areas of northwestern India should be brought together into a politically autonomous unit.

Iqbal's address provided an important intellectual direction to Muslim political thought. It strengthened the idea that Muslims required political arrangements through which they could preserve their religion, culture, traditions, and collective identity.

Historical Context of the Creation of Pakistan — 1930 to 1947

The period from 1930 to 1947 was the decisive phase of the Pakistan Movement. During these seventeen years, Muslim political demands gradually changed from requests for constitutional safeguards to the demand for a separate political homeland. The Round Table Conferences, the Government of India Act 1935, the elections of 1937, the Congress Ministries, the Lahore Resolution of 1940, the Cripps Mission, the Simla Conference, the elections of 1945–46, the Cabinet Mission Plan, and the 3 June Plan were major stages in this process.

Round Table Conferences

Between 1930 and 1932, three Round Table Conferences were held in London to discuss the constitutional future of India. Representatives of different Indian communities and political groups participated.

The central problem was how a constitutional system could protect the interests of India's religious and political minorities. Muslim representatives emphasized that Muslims were not simply a minority whose interests could be protected through ordinary majority rule. They demanded constitutional safeguards, adequate representation, and provincial autonomy.

The conferences did not produce a final political settlement, but they highlighted the complexity of India's communal and constitutional problem.

Jinnah's Return and Reorganization of the Muslim League

During the early 1930s, Quaid-e-Azam Muhammad Ali Jinnah spent considerable time in Britain. However, he eventually returned to India and resumed active political leadership.

After 1934, Jinnah worked extensively to reorganize the Muslim League. He attempted to bring Muslim leaders and different Muslim political groups under one central organization. His leadership gradually transformed the Muslim League into a powerful political party representing Muslim interests throughout India.

Government of India Act 1935

The Government of India Act 1935 introduced provincial autonomy and provided the basis for provincial elections. It was one of the most important constitutional developments before independence.

The Act gave Indian political parties an opportunity to form governments at the provincial level. The Muslim League therefore had to demonstrate that it could politically mobilize Muslims across different provinces.

Elections of 1937 and Congress Ministries

The provincial elections of 1937 were a turning point. Congress performed strongly in several provinces and formed governments, while the Muslim League did not achieve the level of electoral success it had hoped for.

From 1937 to 1939, Congress ministries governed several provinces. The Muslim League criticized certain policies and practices of these ministries and argued that Muslims faced pressure regarding their religious, educational, linguistic, and cultural identity.

Muslim League propaganda emphasized issues such as the promotion of Hindi, the use of Bande Mataram, educational policies, and other cultural matters. The League presented these developments as evidence that Muslims could not safely rely on majority rule without strong political safeguards.

Although historians debate the extent and nature of these grievances, politically they were extremely important because they helped the Muslim League mobilize Muslims around the idea of separate political identity.

Resignation of Congress Ministries and Day of Deliverance

In 1939, the Second World War began. Congress ministries resigned after disagreements with the British government over India's involvement in the war.

The Muslim League observed 22 December 1939 as the Day of Deliverance, celebrating the resignation of Congress ministries. This event further widened the political gap between Congress and the Muslim League.

The Lahore Resolution, 1940

The most important development in the Pakistan Movement occurred at the Muslim League's Lahore session in March 1940.

On 23 March 1940, the Muslim League passed the famous Lahore Resolution. It demanded that Muslim-majority areas in the northwestern and eastern zones of India should be grouped into independent and autonomous political units.

The resolution did not initially use the word "Pakistan," but it became the central political document of the Pakistan Movement. It transformed Muslim political demands and provided a clear direction for future negotiations.

Under Jinnah's leadership, the Muslim League increasingly argued that Muslims were a separate nation with their own religion, culture, history, social values, and political interests.

Cripps Mission, 1942

During the Second World War, Britain needed Indian political support. In 1942, the British government sent the Cripps Mission to India with proposals concerning India's constitutional future.

Congress and the Muslim League had different expectations from the proposals. Neither side accepted the plan completely, and the constitutional crisis continued.

The failure of the Cripps Mission demonstrated that the British government could not easily resolve the differences between Congress and the Muslim League.

Gandhi-Jinnah Talks

In 1944, Mahatma Gandhi and Quaid-e-Azam Muhammad Ali Jinnah held negotiations regarding the future of India.

Gandhi favored maintaining Indian unity, whereas Jinnah insisted that Muslims constituted a separate nation and should have a separate political homeland. The negotiations failed because the two leaders could not agree on the basic question of Muslim nationhood and the political future of India.

Simla Conference, 1945

In 1945, Viceroy Lord Wavell called the Simla Conference to discuss a new constitutional arrangement.

The Muslim League insisted that it should be recognized as the principal representative of Indian Muslims. Congress did not fully accept this claim. The conference therefore failed.

The failure strengthened Jinnah's position and helped the Muslim League demonstrate that no constitutional settlement could be achieved without its participation.

Elections of 1945–46

The elections of 1945–46 were decisive for the Pakistan Movement. The Muslim League campaigned strongly on the demand for Pakistan and won an overwhelming majority of Muslim seats.

These results greatly strengthened Jinnah's claim that the Muslim League represented the political aspirations of a large majority of Indian Muslims.

The elections also created a clear political division between Congress, which claimed to represent all Indians, and the Muslim League, which claimed to represent the Muslims as a separate political nation.

Cabinet Mission Plan, 1946

In 1946, the British government sent the Cabinet Mission to India. Its objective was to find a constitutional solution and arrange the transfer of power.

The Cabinet Mission proposed a loose federation in which provinces would have substantial autonomy and would be grouped into different sections. Initially, both Congress and the Muslim League accepted aspects of the proposal, but disagreements soon emerged over its interpretation and implementation.

The plan ultimately failed, and political tensions increased.

Direct Action and Communal Violence

After the failure of constitutional negotiations, the Muslim League announced Direct Action to press its demand for Pakistan. On 16 August 1946, serious communal violence occurred in Calcutta, followed by violence in other parts of India.

The increasing communal conflict convinced many political leaders that a united India would be extremely difficult to govern peacefully.

The 3 June Plan and Partition

By 1947, Britain had decided to transfer power and leave India. On 3 June 1947, the British government announced a plan for the partition of British India.

Congress and the Muslim League eventually accepted the partition plan. Punjab and Bengal were divided, and the Radcliffe Commission was appointed to determine the boundaries of the new states.

On 14 August 1947, Pakistan emerged as an independent country. Quaid-e-Azam Muhammad Ali Jinnah became its first Governor-General. India became independent on 15 August 1947.

Major Causes of the Creation of Pakistan

The creation of Pakistan resulted from several interconnected factors. These included:

The separate religious and cultural identity of Indian Muslims.

Muslim concerns regarding majority rule.

The Urdu-Hindi controversy and other cultural conflicts.

Muslim political and economic concerns after 1857.

The development of Muslim political consciousness through the Aligarh Movement.

The establishment and growth of the Muslim League.

Constitutional disagreements between Congress and the Muslim League.

The experience of the Congress Ministries after 1937.

Allama Iqbal's political thought and the development of the idea of Muslim autonomy.

The Lahore Resolution of 1940.

The Muslim League's electoral success in 1945–46.

The failure of the Cabinet Mission and other constitutional negotiations.

Increasing communal conflict and the British decision to transfer power.